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【メール原文】

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dear hondo-san,

elections, elections, elections: brazil. israel. and, of course, tomorrow's midterms in the united states.

but first, have we learned anything new? after a wave of right-wing political wins in elections across latin america, does lula's victory in brazil show the region heading back to the left? is vučić's defeat in serbia on the back of orbán's ouster in hungary a decisive blow against russia and a broader vote of confidence toward the european union?

not exactly. or rather, there's more long-term consistency here than meets the eye. the critical factor (which isn't going anywhere anytime soon) is high inflation and affordability concerns driving anti-incumbent voter sentiment. and it's been building for years. on the back of covid, with massive supply chain shocks and extraordinary spending, most of the world's economies experienced a major overhang of inflation. that started to ebb away, only to be pushed up again by another round of supply chain shocks from ongoing disruptive wars in ukraine and iran. and then further still by the extraordinary spending on artificial intelligence and the resources and energy required to power it.

on top of that, perceptions of corruption have combined with the economy not working for typical voters in a mutually reinforcing feedback loop. security—whether international (through support for wars of choice) or domestic (on issues of crime and illegal migration)—is also adding to the mix across europe, the united states, and much of the global south. and social media and algorithmically driven information flows are creating more polarization across democracies, delegitimizing political institutions and electoral outcomes in the eyes of the voters, and in turn exacerbating anti-incumbency and anti-establishment trends.

together, these trends are inflaming passions over political change, leading to higher turnouts and greater anti-incumbency challenges than we've seen in decades. the right wing has benefited from that across latin america because the left had been mostly in power, but the honeymoons are proving shorter accordingly (just look at chile president josé antonio kast already in trouble only a few months into his term), and are set to result in another cycle with political figures on the populist left coming back. that's about to show itself in dramatic fashion in the united states. in europe, illiberal forces that govern badly are being punished (serbia and hungary), but it's still outsiders that have the most momentum—both elections replaced populists-turned-authoritarian-leaning with more grassroots outsiders. and a shoutout for students and youth movements too, who see corrupt gerontocracies spending down their future (and damaging the climate in the process)—it's a leaderless movement that carried the day in serbia, much as we've recently seen in nepal and bangladesh...the students that kicked off the latest round of nationwide protests in france; and also with the most momentum in india that we've seen in over a decade of narendra modi's leadership.

in short, this isn't (and hasn't been) a right or a left wing trend. it's a broader set of beliefs that existing governance, political parties, leaders, and power structures aren't working for much of the electorate.

this is least the case in east asia, because of generally more homogeneous populations, more deeply held communitarian values, and cultural alignment between nation and governance. but most everywhere else, across advanced industrial democracies and much of the world's emerging markets, it's become the major domestic political force in play.

brazil

a big surprise—but not really an exception to this—in brazil. flávio bolsonaro had led the first-round voting by a substantial margin, with voters supporting conservative third-party candidates shut out of the second round expected to vote for him. and yet president lula managed to win by nearly four and a half million votes. what happened?

a few things. tactically, a social media campaign for a candidate who hadn't previously been very adept at digital campaigning was extremely successful in turning out the vote. also negative campaigning against bolsonaro—tying him to corruption, militias, and, most importantly, a fear that the lower and middle classes would have their benefits taken away if he was voted in (the other side of the coin of fiscal restraint that the markets had been so enthusiastic about). but bigger picture, that was plausible for a few reasons. first, because lula entered the election with higher approval ratings than his peers in the region, at 45%, so it doesn't come as a complete surprise that incumbency advantages played themselves out in the second round of the campaign. second, because brazil essentially had two incumbents running for the presidency—the recently turned 81-year-old lula, running for his fourth term in office; and the son of former president jair bolsonaro, sitting under house arrest having been convicted for trying to launch a coup against the result of the previous election.

which also means we should expect a very short honeymoon for lula, especially since brazil also experienced a wave of anti-incumbency in the congress, leaving a right-wing legislature that's going to prove extremely challenging for lula to navigate, and an economy that is decelerating. lula's immediate response will be to try to engage in fiscal restraint, to reach out to legislative leadership for compromise, and to appoint economic leadership that's seen as more moderate. but none of that will prove sufficient to avoid a significantly more challenging domestic political environment than he experienced over his last term.

meanwhile, brazil's political institutions are experiencing a crisis of legitimacy. there were no credible allegations of fraud, but the political narrative around the election has been exceptionally fraught. several cities with conservative mayors were ordered by justices to make public transit available for voters on the day of the polls...and didn't. lula went to the electoral court head (a bolsonaro appointee) who ignored the request to intervene...leading the president to then turn to a supreme federal court justice (himself a former personal attorney for lula), who promptly agreed, extending voting hours across the country (including some in areas where bolsonaro had requested an extension, because of bad weather). none of which mattered to the outcome (the judicial decision only affected tens of thousands of votes), but in an environment where legitimacy is already maximally questioned, a solid majority of bolsonaro supporters suddenly believed the election was stolen.

that wasn't made any easier on the back of post-election political activities. moments after lula won, supreme federal court justice alexandre de moraes demanded the seizure of flávio bolsonaro's passports, as he was under investigation (though not charged) for fraud and money laundering, and believed to represent a flight risk. but moraes is seen as politicized and under suspicion due to his association with daniel vorcaro, who perpetrated one of the largest financial frauds in the country's history. so the decision immediately came across to non-lula supporters as political retribution.

bolsonaro said he would cooperate, but instead promptly fled the country, traveling through argentina (which "took note" of the election result but hadn't yet formally recognized lula), and eventually to miami, where he produced a letter announcing he was the "true president of brazil" (he later revised it to call himself the "leader of brazil," not that it matters), despite his own party having already conceded to lula (president trump said it "looked like another rigged election" but declined to get involved or comment further).

ultimately, it's a hit to brazil's political institutions. the population sees deep and extensive corruption, blames political opposition for lawfare, and sees the supreme federal court as compromised. though with the bolsonaros now under arrest or in exile, and with president trump not inclined to create a new crisis with brazil (saying the bolsonaro family was treated very unfairly, but deciding to stay on the sidelines around the election itself), ongoing trade, critical mineral, and security relations shouldn't change. as the brazilians like to say, brazil isn't for amateurs.

israel

israel is a completely different story. an extremely fragmented political environment, with prime minister benjamin netanyahu's bloc having lost significant seats (slipping from 68 to 53 of the knesset's 120 seats), the question is whether anyone can form a government. at a minimum, it's going to be weeks or months of horse-trading, either to seat a government or to fail and call another election to try for a more definitive result.

the near-term challenge is netanyahu as caretaker prime minister, when the united states is preparing another round of strikes on iran. the israeli government will participate, and bibi sees an escalation of the war—with the intention of bringing about regime change—as a critical legacy for his leadership, and also the best prospect for him to stay in power (and avoid incarceration). that also risks escalation beyond what the americans are interested in seeing. at the beginning of the war, pm netanyahu supported a broader targeting of assassinations than had been explicitly approved by the trump administration; intended to more significantly disrupt the iranian regime but ultimately making it harder for the united states and gulf allies to negotiate an end to hostilities with the islamic republic. in addition, in the initial weeks of the war, israel targeted energy infrastructure outside tehran that resulted in "black rain" across the capital city, with significant health implications for iranians—which the united states specifically had opposed. so the potential that happens again, extremely unlikely under a non-netanyahu government, is not base case but non negligible with netanyahu remaining in place in a caretaker role.

meanwhile (and similar to bolsonaro) netanyahu immediately contested the outcome of the elections, explicitly saying arab voters (israeli citizens, who turned out in large numbers) were a pro-palestinian and pro-terrorist force that had stolen the elections against his likud party and needed to be redressed. none of which has evidence, but netanyahu is essentially "all in" to remain in power, and isn't particularly concerned about the nature of the charges he levies.

unlike bolsonaro, president trump explicitly endorsed the israeli prime minister in the runup to the elections, and will continue to support him as efforts to create a government are underway. and in the context of probable iran strikes in the coming days to weeks, that's likely to play out in the prime minister's favor for staying on.

us midterms

and then, to complicate matters further, we have us midterm elections tomorrow.

it should bring a dramatic loss for the republicans. president trump is at his most negative polling of either of his two terms, with a blended rate of 36% to 37%. voter views of the economy are nearly 80% negative on the back of persistent and rising inflation. corruption has become a top voter issue, impugning trump, his family members, and much of the trump inner circle and cabinet. and the ongoing war in iran, with unclear justification, hundreds of american casualties, and hundreds of billions in cost, has become extremely unpopular. meanwhile trump has spent weeks of rallies focusing on issues that are at best of no concern to most voters (the east wing ballroom, renaming artificial intelligence, and the like), at worst seen as needless distraction, and appearing increasingly incoherent. on the latter, it's worth remembering that biden pretending his health was fine ultimately led to a revolt inside his own democratic party as the primaries picked up; on top of all the substantive policy anger, we're now also seeing a series of similar trump mental acuity issues pick up momentum.

we expect more than 20 seats to swing to the democrats in the house of representatives, and a senate outcome of 51-53 seats for the democrats. if that's wrong, i suspect it's because it's too cautious. the pro-maga vote is roughly the same size as earlier in the year, but levels of voter enthusiasm for trump among the base have fallen off a cliff. and with midterms generally being lower turnout, with the most committed and educated voters actually showing up, if anything i expect the polls are underappreciating how much damage trump has done to his party's cause.

i get lots of questions about whether president trump is going to try to steal or overturn the outcome. the answer is a definitive no. president trump doesn't have the tools, he doesn't have the support within his own republican leadership, the pushback from the judiciary will be near complete (the trump alaska suit that made all the headlines was dismissed yesterday—as expected in the update last week), and the loss to overcome is going to be too steep. that doesn't mean he's going to accept the outcome, and that could undermine voter views of the legitimacy of the process for 2028. but the further trump goes in this direction, especially if the loss is as significant as i expect, the faster president trump becomes a lame duck.

and that's really what's behind the questions for 2027. does a trump republican party hold together behind him? how quickly do key members of cabinet decide to leave and, when they do, how many decide to break decisively, leak information about political issues they disagree with, and potentially even run for office themselves? does the republican presidential primary end up an open primary, or is an 80-year-old president trump, at the end of his political career, still able to determine who the next nominee is going to be?

the democratic primary is completely open and no surprises (yet) there. will be a solid 20 or more candidates, across the political spectrum, with greater focus on economic populism, while engaging less in identity politics and immigration issues. but what happens with the gop in the coming weeks is an entirely different matter. as i've said, we've passed peak trump. let's see how it plays out.

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just back from paris. where the "manifestation" (protests) over the weekend was quite contained, though the damage from the previous weeks was greater than i expected—windows smashed in shops across much of the city. the response from paris was more of a "this sort of thing happens" than you'd get in any other g7 capital; while headlines in the states would make you think there was a lot more disruption.

shall be in new york for elections tomorrow, i'm happy to say. let's see if i'm right about this...

yours truly,

ian

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